Burned Alive

By Souad

SOUAD: **(Pg 1)** I am a girl. A girl must walk fast, head down, as if counting the number of steps she's taking. She may never stray from her path or look up, for if a man were to catch her eye, the whole village would label her a ***charmuta***. A girl must be married before she can raise her eyes and look straight ahead, or go into a shop, or pluck her eyebrows and wear jewelry. My mother was married at fourteen. If a girl is still unmarried by that age, the village begins to make fun of her.

INTRODUCTION

Honor killings. Almost always, the victim is a woman; the killer a male family member. The woman's offense is invariably refusing to bend to the will of her family. She is a sister who falls in love with a man not of her family's choosing, She is a daughter who refuses to agree to an arranged marriage, sometimes to a man old enough to be her father. She is a wife who can no longer stay in an abusive marriage and divorces her husband.

According to the Washington Post, it remains a common practice in Pakistan today, with an estimated 1,000 Pakistani women murdered every year. There are few survivors; Souad was one of the "lucky" ones. This is her story. Burned Alive by Souad.

SOUAD: **(Pg 2-3)** It is a curse in my village to be born a girl. I have no memory of having played games or having fun as a child. The only freedom a girl can dream about is marriage, leaving your father's house for your husband's and not coming back. I dream about it. Ever since I heard that a man spoke to my father about me, I have been consumed by impatience and curiosity. I know [Faiez] lives three or four steps from us. He must have a good job in the city because he never dresses like a laborer. He always wears a suit, carries a briefcase, and has a car. I imagine I am married to him and he'll come back from work at sunset and I will

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remove his shoes, and on my knees I will wash his feet as my mother does for my father. I will be a woman who has a husband!

(Pg 5) As I have mentioned, where I come from, being born a girl was a curse. **(Pg 20)** In my village, if the men had to choose between a girl and a cow, they would choose the cow. My father repeated endlessly how we girls were not good for anything. A cow gives milk and produces calves. What do you do with milk and calves? You sell them and bring the money homme, which means a cow does something for the family. But a girl? What does the family get from her? Nothing.

(Pg 52) Rights do not exist [for women] There are customs. This is the way it is and that is all. If your father points to a corner of the room and tells you to stay in that corner the rest of your life, you won't move from there until you die. If your father places an olive in a plate and tells you that today that's all you'll have to eat, you eat only that olive.

(Pg 34-35) Once, by mistake, I picked a green tomato. It was half yellow and half red and was beginning to ripen. I knew that I shouldn't have picked it but I was working too fast with both hands. My father shouted: You fool! You see what you've done?" He struck me and then he crushed the tomato over my head. "Now you're going to eat it!" He crammed it into my mouth and he rubbed my face with the rest of the tomato. It was acid, very bitter, and smelled bad. I was forced to swallow it. I couldn't eat anything after that because my stomach was upset. But he pushed my head into my plate and made me eat my meal, almost like a dog. He had me by the hair. I felt sick but I couldn't move. The more I said my head hurt the more he persisted din crushing my face into the semolina. Then he wiped his hands on a napkin, threw it at my head, and went and calmly settled himself in the shade on the veranda. I had food all over my face,

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my hair, and in my eyes. I never forgot this green tomato, and the humiliation of being treated as less than a dog. He was the symbol of an enslavement that was taken for granted, that I accepted, bending my back and lowering my head under the blows, like my sisters and my mother. This was everyday life.

(Pg 48-49) Being married was the most I could hope for in terms of freedom. But even married, a woman risked her life at the least lapse in her conduct. I remember a woman who had four children. One day I heard my mother say that the village was telling stories about her. People thought she was involved with the owner of the store because she went there frequently to buy bread, vegetables and fruit. One day my mother said that her brothers had gone into her house and cut off her head. They left the body on the ground and walked around the village with her head. She also said that when her husband returned from his job he was happy to learn that his wife was dead since she'd been suspected of something with the store owner. This woman had been punished for her violation of the rules, this was normal. I didn't realize that simple gossip based on the neighbors' assumptions, or lies even, could turn any woman into a ***charmuta*** and lead to her death, for the sake of the honor of the others. IT is what is called a crime of honor, ***Jamirat el Sharaf***, and for the men of my region it is not considered a crime.

(Pg 72-74) Faiez lives in the house opposite ours, on the other side of the road. [He] works in the city [and] is all elegance. The first time I saw him I was lucky. He came out in a suit, with beautiful black-and-tan laced shoes, carrying a briefcase, very black hair, very tanned complexion, a proud bearing. My heart beat loudly in my chest and my legs trembled. And I said to myself: I want this man for my husband. I love him. I want him, I want him . . .

But what to do? How could I plead with him to go and beg my father to conclude

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the marriage? How could I even speak to him first? A girl does not speak first to a man. She is not even supposed to look directly at him. He is inaccessible. Even if this man wants to marry me, it's not for him to decide it. It's my father, always him, and he would kill me if he knew I lingered for a second on the road to draw Faiez's attention. I decided to do everything I could to meet him in secret and speak to him, at the risk of being beaten or stoned to death. I didn't want to lose all hope of going away with a man, of getting free of my father's brutality.

(Pg 76-77) The next morning, I pretend to be chasing a goat in order to pass in front of [Faiez'] house. He smiles at me – I know he's watching me go off toward the fields with the animals. I can't go any farther in taking the initiative. Now it's for him to decide how he will arrange to speak to me in secret. He knows where I go and when . . . the next day Faiez appears in front of me. He has followed me discreetly and says hello to me. I am ashamed and I look down at my feet, I twist the fabric of my dress and pull on the buttons of my jacket. I don't know what to say. He says: "Would you like us to get married together? . . . You're afraid?"

"Yes, I'm afraid. My father is mean. It's dangerous for you, too. My father could beat both of us."

(Pg 78-83) I have never been so happy. To be with him, so close, even for a few minutes. For the first time in my life I am someone because I myself decided to do what I want. I am alive. I'm not obeying my father or anyone else. On the contrary, I'm disobeying. My first real meeting with Faiez, in the field of green wheat, give me an idea of who I am. A woman who is determined to become his wife at any price.

"Do you want me to speak to your father about the marriage?" Faiez comes

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closer to me, very close. I close my eyes, I'm a little afraid. I feel his hand behind my neck and he kissed me on the mouth. "See you tomorrow. Wait for me, but not on the road, it's too dangerous. Hide here, in the ditch. I'll meet you after work."

And the next day, as I watch him approach my hiding place, my heart is trembling. No one in the house suspects my secret meeting. [But] I'm afraid Faiez wants more than a kiss, and at the same time I want it without really knowing what is waiting for me. I'm afraid that if he goes too far and I push him away, he'll get angry. I also have confidence in him because he knows very well I can' let myself be touched before marriage. He knows that I'm not a ***charmuta***. And he has promised me marriage. But I'm afraid all the same, all alone in this field. Hidden in the tall grass.

We sit on the ground. He tries to place his hand on my thigh. I don't let him do it. He gets annoyed. His expression is mean as he looks at me. "Why don't you want to? Come on!" I'm so afraid he'll go away, that he'll look for somebody else. He is my only hope. So I let him do what he wants. He pushes me into the grass. He knows very well what he's doing. He says nothing, either before or after. He doesn't ask me why I'm crying, and I don't even know why I have so many tears. I didn't want to. I know nothing about love between a man and a woman, no one has taught me anything about it. I don't dare look at him, I'm ashamed. I didn't want to make love with him hidden in a ditch, I wanted what all the girls of my village want. To be married, to have a beautiful dress and go to be in his house. He took advantage of my fear, he knew I would give in to keep him. I begged him not to drop me, to arrange the marriage quickly. A girl who is no longer a virgin, this is too serious, it's all over for her.

He says: "Now go back, change your clothes, and act like nothing happened.

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Especially don't cry in the house."

(Pg 85-87) One morning in the stable I suddenly feel very strange. The odor of the manure makes me dizzy. And later as I prepare the meal, the mutton makes me feel ill. I'm nervous, I want to go to sleep or cry for no reason. Every time Faiez comes out of his house he looks somewhere else, makes no sign to me. It's been a long time, too long, and I don't know when I last had my period, or when it should arrive. If I'm pregnant my father is going to smother me in the sheepskin blanket. So I hide, I pretend to be fine, but it becomes more and more difficult. Summer begins. This lie can't go on for long. I am pregnant and it's been a month since the last time I saw Faiez. **(Pg 88-89)** I believed him, I wanted so much to believe him. [But] I was so afraid that I picked up a big stone and struck my stomach with it hoping to make myself bleed and put things right. **(Pg 93)** I have lost hope. It's over. He's dropped me. He took advantage of me, it was a fine time for him. Not for me. I'll never see him again. [and] I can't ask anyone for help.

(Pg 100-102) The weeks pass. No one questions me, no one wants to know who did this to me, how and why. Even if I accuse Faiez, my father won't go looking for him to make him marry me. It's my fault, not his. A man who has taken a girl's virginity is not guilt, she was willing. And even worse she's the one who asked for it, who provoked the man because she is a whore without honor. I have no defense. My naivete, my love for him, his promise of marriage, nothing of all that counts for anything. In our culture, a man who has self-respect doesn't marry the girl he has deflowered. Did he love Me? No. And if I committed a fault, it was believing that I would hold on to him by doing what he wanted.

One evening - a family meeting. I listen behind the wall, terrified. My mother speaks to Hussein, my older sister's husband: "We can't ask our son, he won't be

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able to do it, he's too young."

"I can take care of her. Don't worry about it. I'll find a way. You'll go out. Leave the house, you can't be there. When you come back, it will be done."

I hear my sister crying, saying she doesn't want to hear this and that she wants to go home. I had heard my death sentence with my own ears. Are they really going to do it? Is it just to frighten me? And if they do it, when will it be? How? By cutting off my head? Maybe they're going to let me have this child and then kill me after. Will they keep the child if it's a boy?

The next day, I act as though I've heard nothing. My mother says to me: "It's time for you to do the washing, your father and I are going to the city." I know what is going to happen. They are leaving the house just as they'd told Hussein.

I first go for water from the well at the back of the garden. I arrange the wood for the fire and sit down on a stone while I wait for the water to heat. **(PG 105 – 107)** Suddenly I hear the door clang. He's there, my brother-in-law Hussein. He says: "Hi! How goes it? I'm going to take care of you." That smile – I wasn't expecting that. "You've got a big belly, huh? " He didn't say anything more. I kept my head down in shame, a little relieved that he didn't ask me other questions.

I suddenly felt a cold liquid running over my head and instantly I was on fire. I start to run in the garden, barefoot. I slap my hair, I scream. I feel my dress billow out behind me. . Was my dress on fire too? I know I'm running and I'm on fire and I'm screaming. I must have climbed onto the garden wall to end up in the street. There were women, it seems to me two of them, and they beat on me, I suppose with their scarves. They dragged me to the village fountain and the water hit me suddenly and I screamed in fear. I hear the voices of women

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wailing over me "The poor thing . . . the poor thing . . " I'm going to die. That's good. Maybe I'm already dead. It's over, finally.

TRANSITION

But Souad didn't die . . . with 3rd degree burns destroying her face and covering most of her body, she survived. And with the help of SURGIR, a Swiss foundation dedicated to working with women who are subjected to criminal traditions, she escaped with her unborn child to tell her story. 30 years after her attempted murder, she explains . . .

SOUAD: **(Pg 197)** I have met girls who have come from afar, as I did years ago. They are in hiding. A young girl who has no legs: She was attacked by two neighbor men who tied her up and put her in the path of a train. Another whose father and brother tried to murder by stabbing her and throwing her into a garbage bin. Still another whose mother and two brothers threw her out a window. She is paralyzed . . . [But] I have never met any burned women like myself; they haven't survived. And still I hide, I cannot say my real name, show my face. I can only speak out, it is the only weapon I have.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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